

UTT Chapter 13 Assignment

Hello!

Sorry I haven't written lately. Classes picked up pretty quickly with the first round of exams. Thankfully, midterms are still a few weeks off. That still doesn't stop us from dreaming about spring break though! Nathan, Sarah, and Paige invited me to go skiing with them in Colorado, but Mark and Muhammad are going hiking in the Appalachians. I haven't been skiing or hiking in several years, so both options sound like awesome adventures. What are your plans for the break?

Over the last few weeks, I have been trying out the fencing team here at the university. After watching a lot of pirate movies with my little brother over Christmas break, I decided to learn how to sword fight. Let me tell you, it is a lot more difficult than you would think. Thankfully, Mark has been going with me, and he is just as bad as I am! It is a great stress reliever after all that studying. If you come up to visit, maybe I can take you to a practice and show you the ropes!

While walking to practice the other day, Mark and I ran into Sarah. She and some other students were passing out flyers in the quad. They were advertising a student government debate about the role of family in society and the state. Obviously, Mark was really interested, so we began to discuss the topic. Sarah said we should encourage alternative lifestyles and family structures. According to her, society should be free from arbitrary constraints that religion places on progress. I assume that her views on the family are grounded in her Secularist views, but I don't know exactly how. **What does Secularism have to say about sociology?** Mark agreed that the traditional idea of the family hinders the progress of society, but he said it was because the family causes the "illicit hoarding of capital and wealth." To be honest, I have no idea what he meant. Mark mentioned Karl Marx's sociological views frequently, so I am assuming that Marxism has a lot to say about the relationship between people and society. **What is the Marxist view of sociology?**

In the middle of the conversation, Muhammad rode up on his bike and joined the discussion. At first I thought our views would be similar since we both believe in a God, but I was just as confused when he began talking about removing the separation of church and state. Unfortunately, Mark and I had to run to fencing practice, so I didn't hear the rest of what Muhammad was saying. Maybe you can help. **What is the role of sociology in Islam? And what is the Christian view of sociology?**

Well, the break between classes is almost over. I can't wait to hear back from you!

See you later!

-Doug

Doug brought up four different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:

1. What does Secularism have to say about sociology?

Secularism holds to the belief that man is naturally good but has been made bad by his society. Well-intentioned individuals created religion and government, but these two structures come with rules that mankind simply cannot live by. Secular sociologists believe that limiting the influence of religion and expanding the progressive political agenda will improve society and our place within it. Ultimately, they adhere to **personal autonomy**—the belief that individuals should have the freedom to decide what is right for their own lives and live in whatever manner brings them the most happiness.

Secular sociologists are particularly critical of the biblical view of chastity, marriage, and family. As Secularists see it, the traditional family restricts sexual freedom, traps women within the home, and unfairly precludes alternative marriage and family structures. As they see it, the entire concept isn't just outdated; it is physically and mentally harmful to individuals and society. As a corrective, Secular sociologists promote a more liberal view of sex and advocate alternative relationships and families. This includes pre-marital sex, cohabitation, open marriages, homosexual relationships, and homosexual families. [13.3]

2. What is the Marxist view of sociology?

Because of the dialectic, Marxists believe that society is continually progressing toward a future communist utopia or a **proletariat society**—a socialist society shaped by communist party officials to promote the values of the working class over the bourgeoisie. Just as humanity is continually evolving biologically, society is inevitably progressing as well. When communism is finally obtained, social and economic inequality will be eradicated and the need for government eliminated.

One thing hindering the advancement of communism is religion. As Marxists see it, the church and its priests are intricately tied to the oppressive bourgeois class. Religious institutions divide the working class, and religious ethics keep the proletariat from rising up against their oppressors. To counter the influence of religion, Marxists seek ways to diminish the influence of the church. Historically, Marxist regimes have accomplished this by placing restrictions upon the church and discriminating against its clergy.

Another hindrance to the advancement of communism is the traditional notion of family and marriage. As the Marxists see it, the bourgeois family structure only leads to the hoarding of wealth and the virtual enslavement of wives. Under communism, marriage is no longer necessary and the burden of

raising children is shifted to the state. Men and women are therefore free to have sex with whomever they want. The resulting children become wards of the government to raise and educate. [13.4]

3. What is the role of sociology in Islam?

While Secularism, Marxism, Postmodernism, and New Spirituality minimize the sociological significance of family, Islam lauds it. There are virtually no boundaries between the institutions of family, church, and state in Islam. The Islamic family is inextricably linked to the Islamic religion, Islamic state, and the **ummah**—the collective community of Muslims around the world.

Islamic society is fundamentally a patriarchal state. Men don't just run the church and rule the state, they are given special status in marriage and over women. The Quran grants men the right to marry up to four wives (4:3), have sex with women taken captive in war (23:1-6, 33:50, 70:22-30), and even participate in temporary marriages (4:24). The Quran allows men to divorce their wives in some circumstances (60:1-2; 65:1-2; 226:242), but makes no mention of women being allowed to divorce their husbands. The Quran even gives men permission to beat unsubmitive women (4:34). [13.7]

4. What is the Christian view of sociology?

Christianity views sociology as three specific God-ordained spheres: the family, church, and state with the family being the glue that binds society. Christians believe society functions best when each of these institutions takes responsibility for its particular domain, a concept known as **sphere sovereignty**. When each sphere is doing its job, all three spheres are in good health. When one takes on too much or too little, all three suffer the consequences.

The church was established for the perpetuation of the gospel message in addition to the protection and aid of the poor. The government was developed for the protection of its people. The family was created to raise and educate the youngest members of society.

According to Christianity, redefining the nature and function of the family is one of the greatest threats to our modern society. Christianity promotes a disciplined commitment to marriage between one man and one woman for life that begets love, fidelity, respect, and children. By raising children and being active participants in society, families can keep society healthy and flourishing. [13.8]